Kejriwal, you think he is the only politician who has a simple lifestyle. Many of us also live simply, only we don't make a song and dance of it,' said Shah, polishing off the chole on his plate.

Since CNN-IBN had been one of the channels to honour Kejriwal, Shah turned to me with a smile. 'I believe you are getting an AAP ticket from South Mumbai to contest the general elections? If you do, I promise we will not get Narendrabhai to campaign against you!' I shot back, 'Amitbhai, I don't want to contest on an AAP ticket and lose. *Wave toh BJP ki hai*. If you give me a BJP ticket, I will be happy to contest!' The response was just as swift. *'Agar aapko BJP ki ticket milti hai, to main uska virodh karoonga!'* (If you get a BJP ticket, I will oppose it.) It was all light-humoured. We all had a good laugh.

As we prepared to leave, Shah called me to one side. 'Tell me, Rajdeepji, what is your honest feedback from the ground on AAP?' My view was that the AAP was a Delhi phenomenon whose success was unlikely to extend beyond the national capital. 'They don't have the organization to replicate their Delhi model elsewhere,' I said to Amit Shah. I even tried to console him with the figures of our election tracker which showed that almost 50 per cent of those who had voted for AAP in the Delhi election had said they would back Modi as prime minister in a general election.

Shah, however, appeared rather concerned. *'Nahi, hum unko lightly nahi le sakte. Desh ke sabhi urban areas mein unki popularity kaafibadh rahi hai. UP mein bhi log unke baare mein baat kar rahe hain'* (We cannot take them lightly, their popularity is rising across urban India. Even in UP, people are talking about them).

The BJP's treasurer Piyush Goyal had commissioned the leading global market research and polling agency, Penn Schoen Berland, to do a nationwide survey ahead of the December 2013 assembly elections. The survey showed that the BJP was well ahead of the Congress and was crossing 200 seats on its own. It confirmed that corruption and inflation were the dominant issues and that Modi's popularity was actually twenty points more than that of the BJP. But it also showed that there had been a surge of support for the AAP after its Delhi election success. Much of the